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Joshua Nations Proverbs

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Proverbs

A. Overview and Summary.

1. Proverbs is one of what is called the wisdom books of the Bible, along with Job and Ecclesiastes. Knowledge is the accumulation of facts, information or awareness of particular subject, whereas wisdom is judgement or insight based upon knowledge that gives means to act, process or apply knowledge to given situations. Someone can have a large accumulation of knowledge, but lack wisdom. Proverbs was written by King Solomon, reported to be the wisest man of his time, and others. It was compiled into book form about 900 BC.
2. The book contains hundreds of individual proverbs that can give us wisdom in making decisions about life, in all kinds of situations pertaining to such things as marriage, sex, debt, alcohol, eating, work habits, relationships and many other subjects. As with Psalms, it is a lengthy book, so we will give only a very brief summary here.

B. Chapter 1 opens with the following: “To know wisdom and instruction, to understand words of insight, to receive instruction in wise dealing, in righteousness, justice, and equity; to give prudence to the simple, knowledge and discretion to the youth— Let the wise hear and increase in learning, and the one who understands obtain guidance, to understand a proverb and a saying, the words of the wise and their riddles. The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction” (Vs. 1:1-7). The chapter concludes with a personification of wisdom as a woman who calls out to those who would not listen or chose fear of the Lord, but with the admonition: “whoever listens to me will dwell secure and will be at ease, without dread of disaster” (Vs. 1:33).

C. Chapter 3 contains a very often quoted verse: “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths” (Vs. 3:5-6).

D. Chapter 5 is a strong warning against adultery, and reminds men: “Let your fountain be blessed, and rejoice in the wife of your youth” (Vs. 5:18).

E. Chapter 6 gives practical warnings and a key verse: “There are six things that the LORD hates, seven that are an abomination to him: haughty eyes, a lying tongue, and hands that shed innocent blood, a heart that devises wicked plans, feet that

make haste to run to evil, a false witness who breathes out lies, and one who sows discord among brothers” (Vs. 6:16-19).

F. Chapter 12 opens with an encouragement to receive discipline and valid criticism: “Whoever loves discipline loves knowledge, but he who hates reproof is stupid” (Vs. 12:1).

G. Chapter 14 contains a warning about going a direction that seems right but without discernment: “There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way to death” (Vs. 14:12).

H. Chapter 15 opens with good advice of how to respond in an angry situation: “A soft answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger” (Vs. 15:1).

I. Chapter 16 includes an often-quoted proverb: “Pride goes before destruction, and a haughty spirit before a fall” (Vs. 16:18).

J. Chapter 18 gives sound advice about not giving an answer before listening to what is presented: “If one gives an answer before he hears, it is his folly and shame” (Vs.18:13).

K. Chapter 22 contains the often-quoted verse about how to raise children: “Train up a child in the way he should go; even when he is old, he will not depart from it” (Vs. 22:6). As a side note, this is not a promise. Some children raised correctly will depart from God’s ways. But it is a general principle that if followed, will result in adult sons and daughters that will live righteously.

L. Chapter 25 concludes with a word about self-control: “A man without self-control is like a city broken into and left without walls” (Vs. 25:28).

M. Chapter 30 was written by a man named Agur, about whom we know nothing, and he is not mentioned elsewhere in Scripture. Here is a key verse: “Every word of God proves true; he is a shield to those who take refuge in” (Vs. 30:5).

N. Chapter 31. The book of Proverbs closes with proverbs written by King Lemuel, also about whom we know nothing. The chapter closes with the well-known description of an excellent wife. Here is a key verse: “Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised” (Vs.31:30).

O. Discussion Questions, Application and Passing it on.

1. King Solomon was indeed wise. But he made mistakes that eventually would bring his once vast kingdom into destruction after his death. His kingdom was divided during the reign of his son into two nations, Israel and Judah. First Israel was conquered by the Assyrians. Then Judah was carried captive into Babylon for 70 years. From what you have learned about Solomon in previous lessons, what were Solomon's mistakes and why did he violate his own wisdom by doing this?
2. Read through the book of proverbs frequently. The wisdom there is from God but, as was noted with the verse about training up a child (22:6), the proverbs are not promises. How should we use these proverbs in our daily lives?

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)

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In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

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